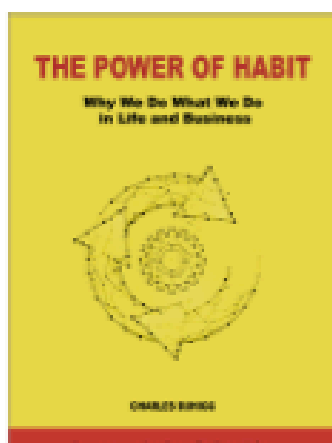




The Power of Habit

Why We Do What we Do
in Life and Business

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The Big "So What"



Habits can be used to create powerful outcomes for individuals, organizations and societies, including losing weight, raising exceptional children, becoming more productive, transforming corporate culture, influencing customer buying habits, and starting social movements. Written by Pulitzer prize winning reporter, Charles Duhigg, **this book presents the science behind how habits are formed, and how we can change and rebuild them.**

Introduction



Habits are automatic responses that often operate without our conscious awareness, and can be extremely hard to change. **By understanding how habits are formed and how they work, we can decide if, and how, to change them.** The book is based on hundreds of studies, interviews and organizational research, and Duhigg zooms in on several case studies in vivid detail. In this summary, we will outline the science of habits at 3 levels - individuals, companies and societies - before sharing the 4-step framework to identify and change habits.

Part 1: The Habits of Individuals



How Habits Work



The Habit Loop summarizes how habits work. There are 3 main components:

KEY QUOTES

"Habits can be changed, if we understand how they work."

"We now know why habits emerge, how they change, and the science behind their mechanics. We know how to break them into parts and rebuild them to our specifications."

"Transforming a habit isn't necessarily easy or quick. It isn't always simple. But it is possible. And now we understand how."

"Simply understanding how habits work - learning the structure of the habit loop - makes them easier to control."



-  **Cue:** This is a trigger (e.g. a TV commercial, a bar of chocolates, an emotion, or a sequence of thoughts) that tells your brain to go into automatic mode, using a particular habit.
-  **Routine:** The automatic response (e.g. feeling irritated, getting a glass of wine) can be mental, emotional, or physical.
-  **Reward:** The routine can produce physical sensations or positive feelings (e.g. pride, relaxation), which determine whether you'll remember this feedback loop in the future.

Once a habit is formed, your default routine will kick in - without conscious thought - each time a cue is triggered. For example, the feeling of stress may cue a smoker to automatically reach for a cigarette, to seek the reward of temporary relaxation.

Our brain converts routines to habits as a way to save effort.

-  Our brain is like an onion, with layers of cells. Complex thinking (e.g. analysis, inventions) happen in the outer layers, primal behaviours (e.g. breathing, swallowing) are controlled by the inner area near the brain stem, while habits are stored in the basal ganglia near the centre of the brain. In short, our habits are created and operated in a different part of the brain from memories and other bodily functions. **Our habits run on "auto-pilot", and we act without consciously thinking why we do so.**

-  **Through the habit loop, our brains learn which cues and routines can bring us desired rewards, and convert them into habits.** Lab experiments show that rats placed in a new maze have initially-heightened mental activities. They take in new scents, sounds and sights as they learn to navigate the maze. Over time, these mental activities decrease and the rats navigate the maze automatically. This is the same

KEY QUOTES

"The cue, in addition to triggering a routine, must also trigger a craving for the reward to come."

"(Habits)...shape our lives far more than we realize - they are so strong, in fact, that they cause our brains to cling to them at the exclusion of all else, including common sense."

"When a habit emerges, the brain stops fully participating in decision making. It stops working so hard, or diverts focus to other tasks. So unless you deliberately fight a habit - unless you fine new routines - the pattern will unfold automatically."

"Habits...emerge because the brain is constantly looking for ways to save effort. Left to its own devices, the brain will try to make almost any routine into a habit, because habits allow our mind to ramp down more often."

reason why we can automatically and effortlessly turn off the alarm clock in the morning, put toothpaste on our toothbrush, or tie our shoelaces.

Cravings and How Habits are Formed



Craving is a crucial element of habits formation. As the cue-routine-reward loop becomes more automatic, we start to anticipate and crave the rewards. **Our craving powers the habit loop to eventually seal in the habit.**

Pepsodent. In early 20th century America, hardly anyone brushed their teeth. Claude Hopkins managed to instil the habit of brushing teeth, making Pepsodent toothpaste a household brand. His ads read, “Just run your tongue across your teeth. You’ll feel a film – that’s what makes your teeth look ‘off color’ and invites decay.” He used the “film” as a cue for people to brush their teeth with Pepsodent, with the promise of clean teeth and beautiful white smiles. The truth is, the “film” is a natural membrane, and toothpaste doesn’t remove it. However, the cue was visible and universal, people wanted the reward (beautiful teeth), and they started craving for the fresh, tingling after-sensation of using Pepsodent. The teeth felt clean, and this sent a signal that the product was working.



Febreze. P&G initially struggled to launch Febreze, a spray that removed odours. Sales went through the roof after they added a fragrance and repositioned it as the finishing touch to one’s daily household cleaning routine. Once people tried the product, they began to crave the clean smell from the finishing spray of Febreze – it made their homes smell clean the cleaning routine felt complete.

Transforming habits



Habits can never truly be removed. You can only **replace and rebuild it**, by changing the routine while keeping the cue and reward constant. This golden rule must be supported by one’s **belief** that the habit can be changed permanently



Changing a cue can avoid triggering the habit loop, but it does not break the habit. The habit lies dormant, and once the same cue surfaces, the habit will kick in again. That’s why someone who has “quit” drinking, smoking or

KEY QUOTES

“Cravings are what drive habits. And figuring out how to spark a craving makes creating new habit easier.”

“Once you break a habit into its components you can fiddle with the gears.”

“We might not remember the experiences that create our habits, but once they are lodged without our brains they influence how we act – often without our realization.”

“The problem is that your brain can’t tell the difference between bad and good habits, and so if you have a bad one, it’s always lurking there, waiting for the right cues and rewards.”

“By learning to observe the cues and rewards... we can change the routines.”

“You can never truly extinguish bad habits. Rather, to change a habit, you must keep the old cue, and deliver the old reward, but insert a new routine.”

“If we keep the same cue and the same reward, a new routine can be inserted.”

gambling may resume the habit when faced with stressful circumstances.



Even if rewards are removed, or even replaced with negative outcomes, we'll have the same automatic reaction to the cues. That's why gamblers continue to gamble even when they've lost everything.



Hence, the only way to change a habit is to intentionally break it down and rebuild it – Replace it with a new routine that will satisfy the same cravings, then find a support group or community to help you build your belief and follow through.



Here are some examples of the Golden Rule at work:

(i) People often use alcohol to forget a worry. At Alcoholics Anonymous (AA), each time a member feels worried or stressed, they talk to their sponsor or join a group gathering, to achieve the same relief via non-alcoholic means. The AA community also provides support and belief to kick the habit.

(ii) Chronic nail-biter Mandy started by using an index card to track her nail-biting urges, and realized the cue was a tingling sensation in her fingers. To break the habit, she developed alternative responses (e.g. rubbing her arms or rapping her knuckles) each time the cue surfaced. That way, she could achieve a similar physical stimulation without biting her nails.



To start making changes, focus on **Keystone Habits** - these are the habits that, once formed, will disrupt and/or influence other habits.

- o People who exercise tend to smoke less, eat healthier foods, and develop other positive habits. Food journaling (writing down what you they eat) helps people to develop more conscious eating habits. A daily gathering with like-minded friends helps someone to maintain focus on a goal and overcome obstacles.
- o **Small wins are a crucial element of keystone habits. They boost morale, build belief, and help us to decide where to focus our efforts.**

KEY QUOTES

"Belief was the ingredient that made a reworked habit loop into a permanent behaviour."

"The precise mechanisms of belief are still little understood... But we do know that for habits to permanently change, people must believe that change is feasible"

"Keystone habits say that success doesn't depend on getting every single thing right, but instead relies on identifying a few key priorities and fashioning them into powerful levers."

"The habits that matter most are the ones that, when they start to shift, dislodge and remake other patterns."

"Small wins have enormous power, an influence disproportionate to the accomplishments of the victories themselves."

- o Under the guidance of coach Bowman, multiple Olympic gold medallist **Michael Phelps** followed a rigorous routine that ran like clockwork. By trying a range of techniques until they found stuff that worked, Phelps and Bowman focused on small wins, made them into mental triggers, and built routines and habits around everything that Phelps did- from what time he woke up, to what he ate and how he trained.
- o Phelps' keystone habit was to "watch the videotape" - his mental visualization of the perfect race - before he slept and when he woke up. By doing this each day, Phelps memorized every detail of the pool, and mentally perfected his strokes from start to finish. During a particular race, he was blinded from water leaking into his goggles; yet, by using the video in his head, he won the race and even broke a World Record.

Part 2: The Habits of Successful Organizations



Keystone Habits in Organizations



Routines are important in any organization - they capture the unwritten rules of how things work, how roles are carved out, and how to "survive" and succeed in an organization. These are typically what the employee handbook will not address, and form the unconscious, automatic "habits" of organizations. **Like individual habits, organizational habits can be created by accident or by design, using the same ingredients of Keystone Habits and Small Wins.**

In 1987, Paul O'Neill became the new CEO of Fortune 500 manufacturer Alcoa. Instead of making typical promises with vague business buzzwords, he announced his goal to make Alcoa the safest company in America, with zero workplace injuries. In 11 years, O'Neill transformed Alcoa from having about 1 accident per week per plant, to a worker injury rate that was 1/12 of the national average. In the same period, Alcoa's income grew 5 times and market capitalization increased by \$27 billion.

O'Neill had zoomed in on safety as a keystone habit and an indicator of habitual change. He made sure that everything centred around safety, e.g. hiring and firing decisions, promotions, 24 hour incident reports. In order to achieve the stringent safety standards, teams had to re-examine their processes, managers had their ears on the

KEY QUOTES

"Small wins fuel transformative changes by leveraging tiny advantages into patterns that convince people that bigger achievements are within reach."

"There are no organizations without institutional habits. There are only places where they are deliberately designed, and places where they are created without forethought."

"Cultures grow out of the keystone habits in every organization, whether leaders are aware of them or not."

"You can't order people to change...So I decided I was going to start by focusing on one thing. If I could start disrupting the habits around one thing, it would spread throughout the entire company."
- Paul O'Neill, ex-Alcoa CEO

"Some habits...matter more than others in remaking businesses and lives. These are 'keystone habits', and they can influence how people work eat, play, live, spend and communicate."

ground and invited bottom-up suggestions... Eventually, these habits rippled to other aspects of businesses, creating greater efficiency, quality, learning and flexibility, and profitability.

Making Willpower Automatic



All of us have a limited supply of willpower. In a study, a group of hungry students were given 2 bowls – one containing chocolate chip cookies, and another containing radishes. Half were told to eat only the cookies, and the other half were told to eat only the radishes. The students were subsequently given an impossible puzzle to complete – those who ate only radishes gave up much faster than those who ate the cookies, because they'd already depleted much of their willpower to resist the cookies.

Likewise, handling difficult situations like angry customers and long queues can sap employees of their energy and discipline. Duhigg shares how Starbucks converts willpower and self-discipline into an organizational habit. For example, Starbucks trains its staff to use the “LATTE” method of handling angry customers – Listen to customers, Acknowledge their complaint, Take action to solve the problem, Thank them, then Explain the reason for the problem. By defining the desired behaviour(s) ahead of time, then following that routine each time the situation arises, you can convert ideal routines into relatively effortless organizational habits.

Besides having well-defined instructional manuals, you also need to give people a sense of sense of control or autonomy, so they willingly adopt these habits.

Using Crises to Build Habits



Habits are so inter-related and deeply entrenched in an organization that they can be hard to isolate and to break. Great leaders understand how to use crises to make fundamental changes.

In 1987, a major fire at London's King's Cross station killed 31 people. The fire hazard had been known for years, yet no action was taken. Many opportunities to contain the fire on the day of the incident were ignored, due to the organization's culture for people to keep to their own roles. Desmond Fennel, special investigator for the incident, realized that things would not change without due pressure. Hence, he deliberately called for public hearings for 91 days, and released a 250-page report detailing the complacency and inadequacies of the organization. The resulting public outrage prompted an organizational revamp and brought about the necessary legislative changes.

KEY QUOTES

"Willpower is the single most important keystone habit for individual success."

"The best way to strengthen willpower and give students a leg up, studies indicate, is to make it into a habit."

"Giving employees a sense of control improved how much self-discipline they brought to their jobs."

"Sometimes, in the heat of a crisis, the right habit emerge."

"Crises are so valuable, in fact, that sometimes it's worth stirring up a sense of looming catastrophe rather than letting it die down."

"Good leaders seize crises to remake organizational habits."



Generally, consumers' buying habits are better predictors of purchases than their demographics and intentions. However, everyone's buying habits is unique. **To shape customer habits, the key is to sandwich a new habit you wish to nurture, between existing habits or familiar routines.**



Retail giant, Target, managed to deduce which of their customers were pregnant, by studying their purchasing patterns. However, when they mailed coupon-booklets for baby items to these customers, the gesture was not well-received. The customers did not expect Target to know they were pregnant, and didn't respond well to the coupons. Target decided to change its approach - it intentionally sandwiched coupons for diapers and maternity clothes between unrelated ads for lawn mowers and wine glasses. This time, the customers assumed these coupons were sent to everyone, and willingly used them.



Radio stations also use a similar technique to introduce and popularize new songs. New releases are sandwiched the other familiar, popular songs, until listeners become familiar with them and the songs become new hits.

Part 3: The Habits of Societies



Habits are a big part of how social movements start, spread and become lasting social change. **In this segment, we'll explain the 3 essential parts of a social movement – the habits of friendship, the habits of communities, and social habits – using the example of the American civil rights movement.**

In pre-civil rights America, seats on buses were “segmented”, with the first 4 rows reserved for white passengers by law. On 1 Dec 1955, Rosa Parks refused to give up her seat to a white man. She was seated in the row behind the white section, where either race could sit, yet she was arrested by the police and put in jail.

Although such incidents had happened many times before, Rosa Parks' incident triggered the famous Montgomery boycott, which became the focal point of the civil rights campaign that changed American history. In the book, Duhigg details the sequence of events. Here's an outline:

KEY QUOTES

“Even though everyone relied on habits to guide their purchases, each person's habits were different... The habits were unique to each person.”

“Whether selling a new song a new food, or a new crib, the lesson is the same: If you dress a new something in old habits, it's easier for the public to accept it.”

“Movements don't emerge because everyone suddenly decides to face the same direction at once. They rely on social patterns that begin as the habits of friendship, grow through the habits of communities, and are sustained by new habits that change participants' sense of self.”



The Habit of Friendship is our natural inclination to help people we like or respect. It's crucial for *starting* social movements. Parks was unique because she was well-liked and well-connected in many social networks, across different social and economic strata. She had friends from diverse backgrounds, from farmers to professors. When news of her arrest got out, one of her friends called for a boycott of the city buses. The news spread, and everyone who knew and liked Park wanted to support her.



The Habits of Communities is crucial for *growing* social movements. Parks' personal ties would not have been enough to drive the movement. It spread due to the "power of weak ties", via people who didn't know Parks personally, but shared common acquaintances or social networks. Being a part of such communities created peer pressures and social expectations; people felt obligated to participate and conform, even if they didn't really want to. This allowed the movement to reach people beyond Parks' personal network, generating critical mass for a successful boycott. Dr Martin Luther King Jr. also came into the picture when his church was used as a boycott meeting venue.



Social habits are what *sustain* a movement; long-term sustainable change sets in when the activities become social habits. This happens when leaders give new identity and ownership for people to continue the movement as social habits.

After 2 months, the bus boycott started to lose momentum. At this juncture, there was a bombing at Dr Martin Luther King's house, triggering fresh responses from the black community. King made a speech calling for non-violence and acceptance. This gave a new perspective on the boycotts – it was no longer just about inequality on buses, but about love and forgiveness of the attackers, with faith of eventual victory for the black community. People started to organize themselves, making their statements in nonviolent ways, and the civil rights movement entered another phase.

KEY QUOTES

"There's a natural instinct embedded in friendship, a sympathy that makes us willing to fight for someone we like when they are treated unjustly."

"People have no problem ignoring strangers' injuries, but when a friend is insulted, our sense of outrage is enough to overcome the inertia that usually makes protests hard to organize."

"Weak-tie acquaintances... give us access to social networks where we don't otherwise belong."

"When the strong ties of friendship and the weak ties of peer pressure merge, they create incredible momentum. That's when widespread social change can begin."

"For an idea to grow beyond a community, it must become self-propelling. And the surest way to achieve that is to give people new habits that help them figure out where to go on their own."

Part 4: Applying the Ideas



Habits are complex and hard to change, but change is certainly possible with the correct understanding and desire. There is no fixed way to change habits, since each person, habit and the underlying motivation are different. Hence, in each chapter of the book, Duhigg covers different examples and scenarios to illustrate possible approaches and permutations. Now, we'll outline his **4-part framework to identify and build habits**.

Step 1: Identify the Routine



Start by identifying the old, negative routine what you wish to replace, such as gambling, snacking, or smoking.

Step 2: Experiment with Rewards



It's relatively harder to identify the cravings that drive our behaviours. For example, are you taking a daily "drinks-break" because you crave a can of Coke, the sugar rush, or the temporary distraction that it provides? To identify the cravings that are driving your habits, experiment with different rewards to test the outcome. Assuming you're trying to wean off the habit of drinking a can of Coke a day:

- Try replacing the Coke with an apple, a coffee, or an activity like chatting with a friend; and
- After each activity, write down the first 3 words or things that come to mind, be it an emotion, thought, or reflection. After 15 minutes, check if you still feel the urge for the Coke.

Step 3: Isolate the Cue



It is hard to identify the specific cue behind a habit because we are flooded with different stimuli and information each day. Most habitual cues fall into one of these 5 categories:

- Location: Where were you?
- Time: What time was it?
- Emotional state: What/ how were you feeling?
- Other people: Who else was around?
- Immediately preceding action: What were you doing just before the urge?

KEY QUOTES

"The problem is that there isn't one formula for changing habits. There are thousands."

"Change might not be fast and it isn't always easy. But with time and effort, almost any habit can be reshaped."

"Individuals and habits are all different, and so the specifics of diagnosing and changing the patterns in our lives differ from person to person and behaviour to behaviour... What's more, each person's habits are driven by different cravings."

"By experimenting with different rewards, you can isolate what you are actually craving, which is essential in redesigning the habit."

"To modify a habit, you must decide to change it... You must consciously accept the hard work of identifying the cues and rewards that drive the habit's routines, and find alternatives. You must know you have control and be self-conscious enough to use it."

Jot down your answers to these questions each time the routine occurs, to identify a recurring pattern in the cues.

Step 4: Have a Plan



Steps 1-3 allow you to define your habit loop, e.g. you may realize that your Coke-drinking habit occurs every afternoon, and it's actually a craving to take a break from work and socialize. You can then draw up a plan, e.g. Set an alarm at 4pm everyday to remind yourself to walk to a friend's desk and talk for 10 minutes.

Other Details in the Book to Look Out For



In each chapter of the book, Duhigg covers examples and scenarios in vivid detail to help us see the cues, routines, rewards involved in habits formation and change. Besides the examples outlined in this summary, the book covers details of lab experiments and brain research, case studies on sports, hospitals, gambling, sleep-walking etc.

For more details, do get a copy of the book, or visit the website www.thepowerofhabit.com.

About the Author

Charles Duhigg (born 1974) is an American journalist and non-fiction author. He is a Pulitzer prize winning reporter for The New York Times, and is best known for his books on habits and productivity. He graduated from Yale University, Harvard Business School, and worked with the New York Times as an investigative business reporter.



He has received many accolades including the George Polk Award, Heywood Broun Award, National Journalism Award, and the Pulitzer Prize for Explanatory Reporting.

KEY QUOTES

"Once you understand that habits can be rebuilt, the power of habit becomes easier to grasp, and the only option left is to get to work."

"A habit is a formula our brain automatically follows... To re-engineer that formula, we need to begin making choices again."